STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



STRATEGY

THE RHYTHM OF MANAGEMENT: THE DAY, THE WEEK, THE MONTH

How fragmented a manager's day is, where chief executives' time goes, the daily, weekly and monthly routines that give it a shape, and a card for your own rhythm.

< 9 min

was how long half of the activities of the chief executives Mintzberg observed lasted; one in ten went past an hour.

MINTZBERG, 1975

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NO. 18 · STRATEGY

In this issue

A manager's week fills itself: calls, questions, problems that cannot wait. A few fixed routines keep the important things from being crowded out: a short daily check, a weekly conversation, a monthly look back.

Henry Mintzberg found that most of what chief executives did lasted minutes, not hours. Decades later, 27 CEOs spent 72% of their working time in meetings. Lean answers with standard work for leaders and short daily meetings in tiers; Andy Grove with a one-to-one of at least an hour. In a children's hospital, daily huddles were part of an effort that almost halved one kind of serious event, though never on their own.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Nine minutes

Henry Mintzberg spent a week with each of five chief executives and recorded everything they did. In 1975 he summed up what he had seen in Harvard Business Review.

“Half the activities engaged in by the five chief executives of my study lasted less than nine minutes, and only 10% exceeded one hour.”

5	½	10%
chief executives, one week each	of their activities lasted less than nine minutes	lasted more than an hour

Mintzberg set the folklore of the calm, systematic planner against what he saw: work that was brief, varied and constantly interrupted, and that leaned towards action rather than reflection.

OUR READING

When the day is cut into nine-minute pieces, the important things need fixed places, or the urgent ones take every slot.

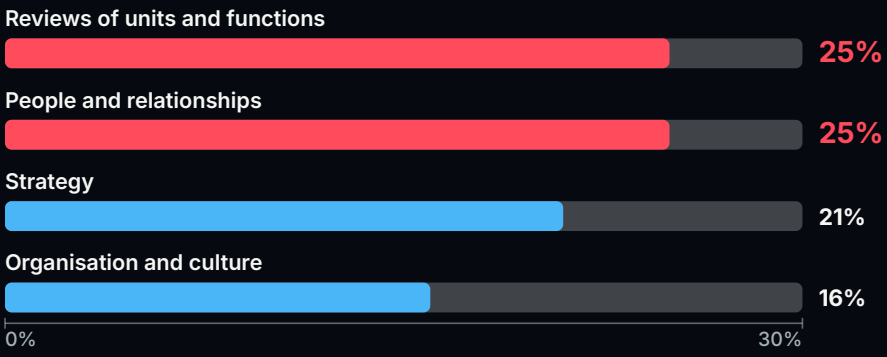
Source: Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975

THE NUMBERS

Where 60,000 hours went

Michael Porter and Nitin Nohria had the assistants of 27 CEOs log their time, around the clock, in 15-minute blocks, for 13 weeks: nearly 60,000 hours. The CEOs worked 62.5 hours a week on average.

SHARE OF THE CEOS' WORKING TIME



72%
of working time in meetings

43%
on work that advanced their own agenda

36%
reacting to issues as they came up

OUR READING

Even at the top, more than a third of the time goes on reacting. A fixed rhythm keeps the rest from going the same way.

Source: Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018

The four areas are shares of all working time and do not add up to 100%.

THE MODEL

A rhythm in three beats

In Creating a Lean Culture, David Mann names four elements of lean management: standard work for leaders, visual controls, a daily accountability process and discipline. Andy Grove adds the weekly conversation.

01	**The day: short meetings in tiers**	The team at the start of the shift, then the supervisors, then the managers: a problem travels up the same morning.
02	**The week: one-to-ones**	At least an hour, with an agenda the employee prepares; more often with someone new to the task, less often with a veteran.
03	**The month: a look back**	The numbers of the month, what the daily meetings kept bringing up, and one change for the next month.

Mann estimated that standard work fills about 80% of a team leader's day. Higher up it fills less, and consists mostly of following up the level below.

OUR READING

A rhythm means fewer meetings: at fixed times, each with one job.

Sources: David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 (via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014); Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006; Andrew S. Grove, 1983 (via Google re:Work's quotation and summaries of the book)

The day follows Mann, the week Grove; the monthly look back is the editors' addition.

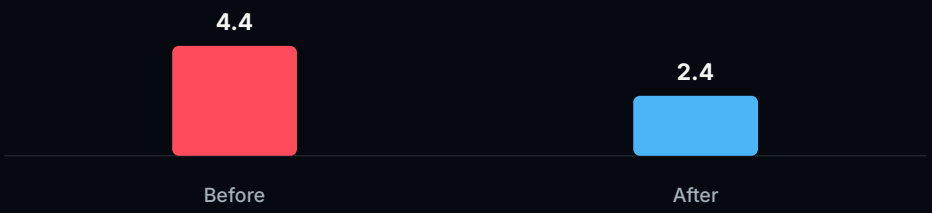
More in the essay — Ten minutes before the shift: what the team needs to know before the work starts

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What a daily huddle can do

A children's hospital with 539 beds introduced short daily meetings in three tiers: on the wards, among charge nurses and among leaders. They looked ahead at risks, reported safety events and moved resources to where they were needed.

UNRECOGNISED DETERIORATION ENDING IN INTENSIVE CARE, PER 10,000 PATIENT DAYS



Events per 10,000 patient days in one children's hospital with 539 beds (Brady et al., 2013). A bundle of measures, no control group: the huddles' share is unknown.

The fall came with a bundle of measures: spotting risk early, frequent huddles on the wards, and ways of learning from each event. There was no control group, so the share of the huddles cannot be separated out. A second study of the same hospital, based on 10 interviews and 6 focus groups, described how the huddles worked but measured no outcome.

OUR READING

A daily huddle costs little. What it is worth depends on what follows: the problem someone takes away and closes.

Sources: Patrick W. Brady et al., Pediatrics, 2013; Linda M. Goldenhar et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2013

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Check the rhythm, not the calendar

In Mann's system, standard work is written down and the level above checks whether it happened. The same works for your own routines.

1. **Write the routines down**
   Each one with a time, a place and an owner.
2. **Mark each one, every day**
   Held or not, in one line.
3. **Count once a month**
   The share held, and why the others fell away.
4. **Change one thing**
   Move, shorten or drop the routine that keeps failing.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD'S MONTH

Daily	19 of 22 meetings held
Weekly	5 of 8 one-to-ones held
Monthly	1 of 1 review held

The weekly routine is the one that breaks, so that is where the change goes. The numbers are made up.

Source: Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006

The editors wrote the steps and the example.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The rhythm card

One card for the routines of your role. Fill it in once, keep it where you work, and check it at the end of each week.

01 Every day time, place, ten minutes, who attends

02 What the daily meeting looks at safety, yesterday's numbers, today's risks

03 Every week one-to-ones: with whom, how long, who brings the agenda

04 Every month the review: which numbers, which question

05 What I stop doing to make room for the routines

06 Who checks me the person who sees whether the routines happened

Sources: David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 (via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014); Andrew S. Grove, 1983 (via Google re:Work's quotation and summaries of the book)

Proposed by the editors, after Mann's daily accountability and Grove's one-to-ones.

Open the tool: Shift Pulse stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-pulse/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Manager's Job: Folklore and Fact
Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975
https://hbr.org/1990/03/the-managers-job-folklore-and-fact

How CEOs Manage Time
Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018
https://hbr.org/2018/07/how-ceos-manage-time

Creating a Lean Culture: Tools to Sustain Lean Conversions
David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 · via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014

Creating a Lean Culture That Lasts: A Conversation with David Mann
Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006
https://www.leanblog.org/2006/11/creating-a-lean-culture-david-mann/

High Output Management
Andrew S. Grove, 1983 · via Google re:Work's quotation and summaries of the book

Huddling for high reliability and situation awareness
Linda M. Goldenhar et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2013
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23744537/

Improving situation awareness to reduce unrecognized clinical deterioration and serious safety events
Patrick W. Brady et al., Pediatrics, 2013
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23230078/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html